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To:
Dr. Andreu Casas
Director, London Social Media Observatory
Royal Holloway, University of London

Subject: Application for the "LSMO PhD Studentship – Social Media and Politics"

Dear Dr. Casas,

I am writing to apply for the fully funded PhD Studentship at the London Social Media Observatory. As a Chevening Scholar (UK FCDO) and MSc Data Analytics (Distinction) from the University of Portsmouth, with a keen interest in the intersection of data science, social media, and public policy. My academic research, technical expertise, and professional experience align closely with the Observatory's focus on algorithmic curation, moderation, and the societal impact of online political discourse on policy making.

My academic foundation reinforces this in my dissertation, "Cross-Platform Sentiment Analysis of Public Reaction to UK Economic Policies" with a distinction, supervised by Dr. Ella Haig. I developed a multi-platform workflow analyzing 279,000 posts across Twitter, Reddit, YouTube, and Quora using BERT, BiLSTM, LIME, NRC emotions, and Prophet forecasting. The model achieved a Macro-F1 score of 0.88, outperforming traditional baselines while introducing a reproducible, transparent framework for real-time public sentiment forecasting. This research provides the groundwork for my proposed PhD expanding from sentiment measurement to investigating how algorithmic moderation and curation influence political discourse and public mood and how it may eventually impact policy decisions.

My Chevening vision is centered on using social media analytics to bridge the gap between government decision making and public sentiment creating data-informed, citizen-responsive governance. The Observatory's collaboration with Ofcom and the Electoral Commission resonates strongly with my mission to see policy changes that are data driven. Through this PhD, I aim to develop computational models that will reveal how social media influences politics, public discourse and democratic processes. Assessing the data of social media and understanding the participation of the public at large will bridge the gap between data science and democratic policy making.

Professionally, I bring over five years of experience as a Data Engineer and Web Scraping Specialist, having worked with six international companies across the UK, Italy, Ireland, Canada, and the MENA region, as well as 300+ freelance clients globally. My professional work spans building scalable data pipelines, architecting lakehouses, and developing AI-driven analytics solutions. I have advanced expertise in Python, PySpark, SQL, and AWS, alongside web scraping frameworks such as Scrapy, Selenium, Playwright, and Puppeteer. I

routinely design and deploy cloud-based ETL workflows (S3, Lambda, Glue, Step Functions, Redshift) and integrate LLMs and transformer models (BERT, GPT, RoBERTa) for sentiment and trend analysis.

As a Data Engineer Consultant at Fluency (M+C Saatchi), I designed large-scale social listening pipelines using Brandwatch and Sprinklr, delivering actionable insights for clients including the UK Government, Amazon, Ford, and Reckitt. At ViralData, I trained custom LLMs on Meta engagement data to transform social signals into predictive, monetizable intelligence for marketing and civic applications. I currently handle data engineering for large-scale social-listening programmes supporting the UK Government's public-communication initiatives. Using Brandwatch and Sprinklr integrated with custom data-pipelines, I collect and analyse cross-platform conversations to measure public sentiment, narrative shifts, misinformation trends, and share-of-voice across economic and policy topics. These dashboards inform communication strategies and policy messaging at departmental level. This direct involvement with algorithmic data streams and moderation signals has provided a deep understanding of how visibility and engagement are shaped by platform design experience that naturally transitions into the Observatory's research on algorithmic governance and public discourse.

I am particularly drawn to the Observatory's interdisciplinary setting, where data science meets political communication and public policy. Your research especially *"The Geopolitics of Deplatforming"* (2024), *"Academic Access to Social Media Data for the Study of Political Online Safety"* (2025), and *"Who Leads? Who Follows?"* (2019) has been deeply influential in shaping my understanding of how platform governance, visibility, and data accessibility affect democratic discourse. These works inspire my ambition to examine algorithmic curation and moderation through both computational and policy lenses. With a background in large-scale data engineering, machine learning, and cross-platform social-data analysis, I am confident I can contribute methodologically and substantively to the Observatory's ongoing projects on content moderation and algorithmic transparency.

Thank you for considering my application. I have attached my CV, research proposal, and MSc dissertation as the writing sample. I would be honoured to contribute to the Observatory's mission to make online political communication more transparent, accountable, and data-driven.

Warm regards,

Asad Ikram

MSc Data Analytics (Distinction, Chevening Scholar, University of Portsmouth)